Three is an Army

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Mature

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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by Nexus_Nexus

Summary

Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio work together after the war ends to try and build a new life, but their discoveries about the world and all the lies within lead them towards a far darker path.

The Serpent (Intro)

"Quit shaking the raft, Kyle"

"Sorry"

"And don't apologize"

"So- okay, Lonnie"

It had been six days since we were out at sea, and our supplies were running low. Kyle suggested we turned around and went back to shore, but I had thought we were closer to the islands than we really were. We pushed on, and our makeshift raft held itself afloat. The Serpent beneath us was our only real comfort in the vast expanse of nothingness, occasionally a bird flying by or a piece of a wrecked Salineas ship bouncing off us. It was a desolate week before we arrived ashore our final home. The boys looked tired, exhausted, but I held myself together for their sake. It was my fault we had been on the run in the first place. We could never return to our home, not without some serious change, and for that I've felt an unbearable guilt.

The stars looked beautiful that night. I remember my brain, delirious and dehydrated, making shapes and scenes by connecting them. I saw our friends in the stars, those who survived and those who did not. I saw the Horde, the New Fright Zone, Salineas, and more. I saw death. The blank space in between the stars grew larger and beat like a heart, filling my vision with the billowy black that we had been running from. Each pinprick of light splattered golden blood onto the great destroyer of worlds that was the night sky. I was petrified by the sight of it. I saw him lean his head down towards me and grin, as if he knew what was to come and what had already passed. I saw the stars grow and shine once more and his face suddenly disappeared and all that was left was me, Kyle, and Rogelio. Three drifting friends, abandoned by all homes, sailing for a new one. Of all the armies I fought for, this one was the only one that fought for me too.

"Kyle? Rogelio?"

"Yeah?"

"Goodnight"

The Old Fright Zone

The place was a mess. I stood still, holding my nose as I peered into the room. What was once the living quarters that I shared with Kyle and Rogelio was overrun with vines and plants. The air was thick, humid, and putrid with the scent of rotting flowers. Browning petals and leaves littered the floor, mold and fungus taking them over slowly. When the Horde fell and the flowers appeared, we all felt wonder. Wonder was soon replaced by skepticism and then sheer panic. The three of us were on the run, hiding in the Crimson Waste, but we turned around after the sky exploded and hoped to see our home in a better state than when we left it. I saw a scratch mark on the wall and remembered the reason why we left in the first place. The manic nature of the old war and new leaders had spiraled down until it destroyed itself, leaving only a mess of tangled woods. I waded around, trying to find something, anything that was normal, but every corner was interrupted by protruding limbs and arms of a giant, green creature. Once polished and shiny steel was rusted and red, making it seem like we had not set foot in the Fright Zone for millennia.

I backed out of the room and into the hallway, now open to the sky as the roof had been caved in. I climbed up and out, spotting Kyle and Rogelio treading through the rubble. I peered even farther and saw another group of people, maybe ten or more, doing the same as us. There may have been thousands of people trapped in the Fright Zone. Years later there were still people missing, stories of near death and those who barely escaped the collapsing fortress. Many doors were sealed shut by vines, many towers collapsed under a new weight, many soldiers never saw the light of the newly-blue sky. I looked farther atop my perch, squinting my eyes at the blinding sun. I saw a large bird swooping overhead, an odd sight to see since there had never been a bird in the Fright Zone when I had lived there.

Unshaded from the blistering sun on our necks, I walked with Kyle and Rogelio over to the other people I had seen. The sound of

bugs and animals flying around shook my ears, slowly breaking away at my consciousness. The heat, the brightness, the loudness of it all billowed and boiled in a slow, hypnotizing fashion. By the time we were close to them, my legs were moving on their own accord, my brain sailing far off in the distance. The old walkways and corridors had all been eroded to the point where walking over them was tough and draining. The three of us were breathing heavily, drenched in sweat, and ready to collapse by the time we got to the group of people. I had never seen them before, which was not surprising. They still had on their uniforms from the now forgotten war, most of them ranking the lowest possible. They were common soldiers. They sat in a patch of scrap metal that acted as a sort of clearing, a large flat space with hardly any vines or roots to break our stride. Most of them were fast asleep, tarps haphazardly strewn about in makeshift tents and covers from the blinding sun. Only two people out of the large group saw us coming, and one of them turned their head lazily away from us with indifference. Not a word was uttered. Kyle and Rogelio collapsed, ready to fall asleep in the artificial shade. I stayed awake, my mind slowly returning to me. All I could think about was one thing: *where do we go now?*

Behind us, over a mound of abandoned buildings and factories, was an enormous river. We never called it anything back when we lived there, in fact it was really only used by waste dumps, freight barges, and military ships. It was the river we went down to capture Salineas and the Sea Gate. Staring at it then was a trip through another world, though, since for the first time since I was alive the water was clear. The murky grey of the old, unnamed waterthing that had snaked through the Fright Zone before had turned into a real, actual, clean river. In the coming years it came to be known as the River Hope. It was a symbol of our future, our rebuilding, and our unity. Hope was everything we needed.

Hope was all we had at first. The many groups of survivors slowly accumulated as we trudged through the wasteland, our numbers eventually rising into the thousands. Many ration bars and other spare morsels of food were scavenged from the waste, but lots of it was either covered in fungus or burnt to a crisp. Many buildings

caught blaze, according to the words of the people who had been there when it happened. The only person in the group we had first encountered that was willing or able to talk, Rosalia, had lost her brother to a fire in the factory where he was working. When the vines grew around the machines and the many metal furnaces, they caught ablaze. It was a miracle the whole place didn't catch, although in the state it was in now, it would have. Dry leaves and dead flower petals were all that stood between our feet and the metal floor. If a fire had started then, the entire Fright Zone would be a ball of flames in a matter of minutes. Or at least I had thought.

It turns out when the air isn't full of smog, the sun is shining, and the factories aren't billowing smoke, you can see much farther than before. I had never gotten a sense of the true scale of the Fright Zone until that day. For miles and miles as far as the eye could see, all it saw was buildings and skyscrapers. A metal jungle of sorts, now turned into just a regular jungle. If I wasn't starving, I would have found it somewhat beautiful. Sometimes we would visit in the coming years. Every so often we would make the journey down the River Hope and through the decrepit old graveyard. It was the largest tomb on the planet, and less inhabited than the Crimson Waste. No one was sad to see it gone, only a little homesick.

"Lonnie! Come on, come on!"

I groaned, the sound of Kyle's screeching voice cutting into my pleasant dream.

"They saw something I think!"

It was the dead of night, the moon was still high in the sky, the stars freckling the face around it.

"Get up, I'm serious! I think it's... him."

I sat up immediately. The sound of a crowd murmuring and brewing with excitement buzzed around my ears like a swarm of bees. I got up, put on my boots, and walked over to where they were gathering. The slow buzz loudened and loudened, like a horde of cicadas. They saw something.

"It's him! He's come back!"

"We're saved! Look at the size of that thing!"

"I hope they brought food."

The elated cries of tired soldiers started getting more and more manic, rising into a chorus of cheering and chanting. Thousands of voices joined together to call home someone I had long thought to be dead. On the river in front of us was a giant barge, a ship that could fit almost all of us. Waving from the flagpole was the crest of the Horde Empire, the nation we had chosen to leave. Standing at the bow was none other than Hordak himself.

"We can't get on that ship."

"Why not? It might be our only chance!"

"He will kill us. He *will* kill us."

"No, that stuff is over, Lonnie. He probably doesn't even know we deserted."

"He *always* knows! He knew about Catra, he knew about Shadow Weaver, he'll know about us."

We sat there, silent, and thought. I could tell Kyle knew I was right. If that had been the old Hordak, I probably would have been too. Fortunately for us, it was not. For some reason, She-Ra had decided to spare the fucker's life, leaving us to deal with him. More specifically, Entrapta. She may be a genius, but she is the most annoying person on Etheria. The only issue was, she was the only thing standing between Hordak and us. He seemed much more kind and calm, but I could tell it was a facade he held up

whenever she was around. I don't know if they were married or something, they only ever called each other work partners, but there was really a connection there that he wanted us not to see. The issue is, I see everything. I have to.

That night was long. Getting thousands of people aboard a ship, even an incredibly large one, takes forever and is not a very riveting process. By the end, my legs had swollen up and cramped, my eyes had gone fuzzy, and my stomach rumbled. People in Salineas Navy uniforms manned the ship, giving out food and blankets to everyone they could get their hands on. The Fright Zone may have been hot during the day, but the night was bitter. Our breath turned the deck of the ship into a cloud, making my tired eyes see even worse. But as the ship moved along the River Hope and the skyline faded off into the distance, my eyes were fixed right on it, and I saw our old world disappear just fine.

Black Box

I did not like this mission one bit. It wasn't the danger, it wasn't the lack of information, it wasn't even the fact that I had to see Catra again after decades. It was that Kyle and Rogelio couldn't come with me. I could have sworn that Hordak wanted us separated on purpose, that he was waiting for any excuse to find a mission I could go on without them. He hated that we were happy, and I hated him for it. I never got over his position as the leader of the New Fright Zone, especially after how terribly he led the last one. Although he was kept in track by Entrapta, he would often have wild and uncontrollable fits of rage that would be taken out on anyone near him. Because I was the highest ranking military officer, I was usually the one near him. Years later, after a heartfelt conversation with Entrapta, I learned that Hordak's explosions were not entirely his fault, more of a byproduct of his decaying body. As he approached his death, Entrapta kept replacing more and more of his old, broken body with newer technology. Skin and bone became metal, slowly but surely taking everything from him except his brain. At that point, any malfunction in the machinery could be felt by all of us. Even I felt a little remorse as I saw the fear and heartbreak in Entrapta's eyes when she finally switched him off. But as I sat on the boat, surrounded by an unfamiliar crew to command, floating down the River Hope, I hated that son of a bitch with every fiber of my body, and I was right to do so.

We were not docked in Salineas for long. As we neared the palace I could see the guards swimming underneath us already preparing for a swift briefing and then an equally quick sendoff. Queen Mermista was not among them, most likely off in Bright Moon, but King Sea Hawk was. He approached the boat, looking slightly more nervous than usual, and held out a small black box. He did not meet my eyes as he handed it to me. Behind him, the dripping wet guards stood stiff and saluted me. The air smelled horrible.

"Captain Lonnie, thank you for agreeing to this mission."

"I didn't agree to anything. Hordak *made me* do this."

"Well that doesn't matter. I'm giving you this as a replacement for a formal briefing. You won't be needing one."

"What's in it?"

"I can't tell you that. Not even my royal guards know what's in it. If you show anyone besides yourself, or if someone steals it, you and whoever else saw it is ordered to be executed by the Royal Salineas Court." He said the last sentence with a particular sadness in his voice. I could tell he did not want to be in this position, whatever that was. If Sea Hawk was acting like this, I knew that the mission was nothing good. If it were a search and rescue, other kingdoms would be notified. Salineas would not be giving me a black box, Bright Moon would be. I had no idea what I'd gotten myself into, but I knew that it was going to end poorly. Stuff like that always does.

I walked back onto the deck, black box in hand, slightly more anxious than before. Behind me the guards grew fins and swam away, Sea Hawk staying on the dock to watch our ship sail off. He had no expression on his face. I ate dinner with the crew as the sun sank, not speaking a word. It was silent as we ate, the light bulb above us dimly illuminating the room in a yellowish green glow. The air smelled horrible.

The jungle was thick and uncompromising. Mud covered the ground instead of dirt so our footsteps sank down into the earth more each time we moved. We had enough food and water packed for weeks, but each day felt like more than that, especially since sleeping was nearly impossible in such a hellhole. The noises of nighttime were louder than any mechanical sounds I was used to in the factories of the New Fright Zone. Insects, birds, twigs snapping, rocks falling, unfamiliar footsteps circling, all of them created a canopy more claustrophobic than the ceiling of leaves and vines above us that blocked out the sky. We could hardly tell if it was day or night. The only reason we were in that damn place

was because of the mission. We learned halfway through that deserting the mission would result in our executions. Salineas sure did like killing people.

An old woman gave us this hint, she said she was sure she saw Catra go into this forest and that the only way she survived would be if she was taken in by the tribes who lived there. She seemed to know quite a bit about them, she probably used to live in one. Her skin was an odd tinge of magenta and she sounded wise beyond our time. That or she was batshit crazy, it really could have been either one. She met us in the city of Phobos, a busy port city off the western coast of Salineas after the Lieutenant General directed us there. Although it was in the same Kingdom, Salineas' reach along the coastline was immense. The journey took us a week, a whole week where we barely spoke to each other besides the basic questions and answers that we were required. Arriving in the harbor, surrounded by bustling crowds of fishers, traders, and the navy, the woman blended in perfectly. She only caught our attention by grabbing my arm as we walked past her. Turning to see who it was and to brush her arm away, I found myself trapped in her cold grip. She raised her head slowly and stared into my eyes before saying what she knew. When she was done, she let go and walked away, seemingly disappearing into the crowd. I figured it was just a royal guard in disguise or maybe even Mermista's grandmother. She was certainly old enough.

So we headed directly north under the guise that this woman knew what she was talking about. It was seventeen days until we eventually stumbled across what we were looking for, in which one of our group members died of a mysterious disease. It was a horrible journey through the jungle, one that almost killed the rest of us too. There was hardly solid ground to be found, leaving us to have to sleep in trees instead. Our boots and uniforms were constantly soaked, and many of us were ridden with mosquito bites. After the first day, we all decided that keeping our helmets on was the best course of action, even if the humid air fogged our vision and made breathing an uphill struggle. Each day followed the same basic routine. We would wake up, tired and sore, eat

some rations, walk for hours without speaking a word, eat some more, then try to sleep again. We were constantly exhausted to the point of serious concern. I was usually seeing double, and when I wasn't, I was straight up hallucinating. Other members of the group mentioned hallucinations as well, and everyone knew how tired everyone else was. We spoke even less than we did before, going days without opening our mouths. The fear of death hung over all of us, both if we pushed forward and turned back, and the hopelessness was taut like a string waiting to snap on us all. Eventually it did, as one of members broke out in a horrible black rash. They first started scratching eight days into the journey, itching at their upper left leg. The next day they were itching their arm too, slowly growing more violent in their repetitive actions. Three days later, we let them sink down into the mud as they collapsed one last time, not breathing. Panic began to break out between the remaining members of the team as we all struggled with our own horrors. It was hell on Etheria.

I saw the vision of a little girl, one I had never seen before, in the forest a few days before we eventually finished our journey. My hallucinations had become more realistic, more disturbing, and I often heard sounds that were never there. The little girl had been creeping at the corners of my vision for a while, always disappearing before I could turn to look at her. Oddly enough, the woman that we had met before was also there sometimes, standing behind or with the girl. They would never be close by, always just too far to get a good look at. That was, until we got further along our route, and I got more and more tired. One night, I woke up in my perch on a tree to a loud breathing noise. My first thought was that it was some sort of animal that was stalking us. As I opened my eyes and started reaching for my rifle, what I saw shocked me. Sitting on the end of the tree branch, not bending it at all under her weight, and staring directly into my eyes was the little girl. She was breathing heavily, looking just as scared of me as I was of her. She began to cry and open her mouth to scream, but as she did so I blinked and she was gone.

The Crimson Waste was a cake walk compared to what we had been through in the previous weeks. After our bout with the local tribes in the Jungle, and our new destination in the heart of the desert, we were about ready to give up on the mission entirely. The only thing between us and the danger of death ahead of us was the certainty of death behind us. The black box in my backpack was a crude reminder of the threat put against us by the Kingdom of Salineas. However, once we got there, we soon realized that the once harsh wasteland had become somewhat tamer over the years. Ever since Scorpia and Queen Perfuma moved in and started getting more chill, so did the people there. Roads sprang up, buildings got built, even a garden was constructed where the soon-to-be capital would be. The Crimson Waste became a proper kingdom after a while, not just a crack den of every misfit from all the other ones. The road we walked down had solid ground, it had some shade underneath a cave opening or crevice floor every once in a while, and we were restocked with food and water so we were set. The blistering heat of the daytime was overstated by excited travelers and the cold of the night was milder than we had expected. For once we were overprepared.

The town of Lagarto was an old settlement, originally built there by the Scorpion Kingdom before they were wiped out by the Old Horde. After the conquering, most of the Scorpion territory in the desert was abandoned, including Lagarto, and it slowly turned into what we knew it as when we were kids. A group of smugglers eventually found it and turned it into their hideout, where it slowly grew once more. Kids started being born in the Crimson Waste, making it more of a home for more people. When the Queens took power, this town was one of the places they wanted to rebuild, Scorpia having been there before the old war ended. More wells, more roads, more farming, and more people came to the small village until it tripled in size, at least when we had found it on our mission. I have not been there ever since, so it's probably even bigger. It is not the largest town in the Waste, although it certainly is a large tourist attraction among outsiders. The capital, what people call the Desert Heart, was much more central and a

truly scalding place if you were not used to it. The gardens there were built only so Queen Perfuma would feel more at home, or so I've heard. It is not open to the public and so no one really goes there. I've set foot in that city only once on a diplomatic mission for the New Fright Zone, to agree on land that we wanted to use, but that is all I've seen of it. The Waste was nothing like the place we had once known. And that is what we discovered in Lagarto, the last stop on our mission to find She-Ra's wife.

"Okay, this place is *big..."*

"Yeah you could say that again."

"What do we do, Captain? We're never gonna find her here!"

"Well we're going to have to start asking around. We need to see if there's an inn we can stay at and actually get a good night's sleep for once."

"Roger that. I feel like I probably have scoliosis from sleeping in those fuckin' trees."

"Funny, since I've been carrying the whole mission on *my* back."

"Hey-"

"I'm joking, let's just keep going." Memories of our lost member stopped my usual banter in its tracks. I had noticed they had been very close with another member of our team (Sam and Alex were their names). Alex died later on in the mission after we were attacked at sea, joining his partner wherever they are now. I did not want to make our situation even worse by talking down to them, even though it's what I usually would have been doing at the time. I saw his mouth quiver a little bit through the foggy visor in his helmet, a feeling that he kept to himself. I shot an attempt at a warm smile, then I kept moving on. There was no time for this.

The second day out at sea was much calmer than the first. The wind had died down so we relied mostly on our engines to propel us. I sat amongst the many boxes of supplies in our lower deck, hiding with my own thoughts. I missed Kyle and Rogelio so much, even though I had barely just left them. The boat was entirely steady with no noticeable rocking back and forth. For once, I missed the feeling of something moving under my feet because the stillness was so much worse. Just the day before there were many violent waves, constantly breathing in and out and shaking our puny ship. My stomach churned at the time, but seemingly as soon as I got used to it the breathing stopped. The planet was still and we were moving slowly.

The black box sat at my feet, still unopened. My hands had felt over it obsessively for the past few hours, fidgeting with it while my brain wandered. I had not given it any thought since I was handed it the day before, even though I knew whatever instructions were inside would be important. We would figure out more once we got to Phobos like the Lieutenant General had told us back home. He was the one to deliver the message of the lost Queen in the first place. He did not have a black box, nor did he look at us with those eyes, the eyes of someone who know something you don't. He seemed distraught, depressed even. He told us about how he had carried Catra in his boat on the way back to his hometown for weeks and did not know who she was. I didn't blame him, she stopped talking to outsiders years ago. A part of me still missed Catra, even now I reminisce on the days where she used to hang out with us, even if we were all mean to her. She deserved Adora, which is why I was so confused about why she decided to run away. Nothing about this mission made sense.

Looking down, my attention finally snapped back to the present, to the physical. I saw the black box in my hands, featureless, without corners or sharp edges, completely matte, closed tightly. With a small exhale, I put my nail along the seam and pushed up, the lid coming open with a click.

"Captain, I see something ahead!"

"Don't mess with me, you said that two days ago."

"No, really this time, I'm sure!"

"Captain, I see it too!"

"You were hallucinating yesterday too, you guys are just being tricked 'cause you're hungry."

"Captain-"

"Not now, we just need to keep-"

"Captain! I see it too. We've made it."

I looked up, finally seeing what the whole group had seen before me. In front of us, undeniably real, was a clearing and a village. There were houses, there was smoke, there were people. Some of them turned to look at us, five or six weary soldiers with tattered uniforms all walking out of the dense jungle around their world. Slowly, commotion started brewing as we got closer and more people saw us. A few of them carried metal spears and wore masks. Some of them were completely naked, some of them were adorned in beautiful clothing. Surprisingly, many of them looked just like me; their skin was incredibly dark, their hair was matted, thick and unruly. They spoke amongst themselves in a strange language I could not understand, something I had not even considered while making my way through the trees. We had been just barely dragging on for days, not even thinking about how the people we needed to find would not be able to communicate with us. The air smelled sweet, like candy was being shoved into my nostrils. Across many trees was a banner as green as the world, a small drawing of a knife right in the middle. The greenness of the surroundings suddenly dawned on me. I had never seen this much green in my life, even in the jungle there was always brown on the ground. The grass was green, the trees were green, the ferns were green, the people wore green, their houses were adorned in green, and the sky was green right along with it. I did

a double take, looking back up at the sky, it was blue. It was about then that my eyes closed and I fell to the ground, slower than I should have been moving.

I came to my senses lying in a cot staring up at the ceiling. Slowly, timidly, I propped my tired back up and looked around the room. There was a doorway leading outside, no door; a small table sat beside the bed, a small wooden figurine on top of it; the floor was made of packed dirt, the walls and roof made of wood, woven leaves and twigs, intricately tied together in an octagon. Outside the room there was a small child sitting at a table, playing chess with an older woman. The chess set was hand-carved, I could see the little divets and scratches that carving knife had made in each of the pieces. I didn't have the energy to get up, nor did my legs have the strength to hold my weight, so I sat there and watched as the little girl and the old woman played. The woman was wearing an odd wooden mask, also crudely hand-carved out of the same type of wood as the chess set. She did not move her head, nor did the mask have holes for eyes. The girl made small noises each time she moved, occasionally guiding the woman's hand after making another noise herself. They didn't sound like the language the tribe spoke, I guess it must have been some older tongue that fewer people knew. The woman won a game, and then another. The next game, the last one I saw before falling back asleep, the girl ended up winning. I saw her face light up, as if it was her first time winning a game against this elder. I had never seen someone so happy in my life.

When I woke up next the first thing I was the little girl from before. She was folding some clothes and putting them on the table next to me, looking straight into the wall as if thinking about something else. I turned my head slightly and saw that she was folding my commander's uniform, my helmet down by her feet. Everything was washed and the holes had been patched up. Noticing me move, she turned to look at me. Her eyes were honey-colored, similar to mine, and much more mature than the rest of her. For a second, she stared at me up and down as if noticing the same physical traits as me. Reluctantly, she opened

her mouth and spoke to me in my language, although she had obviously only started learning it.

"How are you?"

"I'm okay, thank you."

"Okay...?"

"I am good." I spoke slowly, not knowing how much she could understand. She spoke slowly too, taking long pauses between words as she was trying to remember them.

"Hello, my name is Malaea. And yours?"

"I am Lonnie. It is nice to meet you."

"Good meet you, yes. I no good etherian speaking."

"You *are* good!" I showed two thumbs up and smiled. It was nice to hear her care. As of now, I've been on missions into countries and peoples that don't speak common etherian and there's usually at least one person who know it. I've started learning their languages too, since after this encounter with Malaea I realized how nice it was to be able to talk to somebody. I met one of my closest friends in Aradom because I spent quite a while learned their language. Them and some parts of the Western Kingdom of Snows spoke Aradomi, an odd tongue that sort of sounded like the one spoken in the jungle. They were one of the New Fright Zone's biggest enemies, holding an immense grudge due to the Old Horde's brutal conquest of their land. Countless thousands and maybe even millions were killed in our raids, even though I never really knew that. No one in the Horde had ever known the scale of the empire. We were all told that we were the underdogs, constantly losing territory in the west. In truth, the Aradomi people were driving us back off of them, but only after month-long conflicts that cost their people their lives. Despite all of this history, I went there to study their language and religion in hopes that I could serve as a better diplomat than what we were trying before. I had consulted Hordak about it and he approved, this had

been before the big outbreaks had started, while he was still relatively level-headed. Eventually, I studied there for four years (bringing along the boys of course), learning all about their country and their people's traditions. Eventually, the three of us changed positions from military commanders to international diplomats. For a while, we would go to other nations wide and far, islands that "belonged" to other kingdoms, and especially our opponents in the war. We made friends in each country, starting with Aradom. This little girl in this little village that helped me survive in a little hut with my little squadron of little soldiers helped me solve this colossal issue. I've heard that many more people have followed in my footsteps, and the New Fright Zone recently started bringing in teachers from different regions to teach their language to students. The world is changing.

"Thank you, woman. You is good. Happy."

"I am glad." I sat in thought for a second, then realized this could be an opportunity. No one else could tell me if Catra had come through the village but her. "I need to ask you a question."

"Question. Yes, I say you answer."

"Okay, thank you. Did you see a cat woman here?" I made movements with my hands and arms to mimic what I was saying. I felt ridiculous, but it was all I had.

"Cat?"

"Animal, meow. With ears like this. And fur, not skin, like this."

"Cat." Instantly, the intent look of concentration on her face faded away. Her eyes glassed over, tears beginning to form. Her mouth started curling downwards, but then immediately shot back to a resting state. Her eyes snapped on to mine, her tears still glistening. She did not change the tone of her voice. "Yes, I see cat. She here, now she leave. I see her."

"You saw here leave here?"

"Yes. She here long time. She leave last day."

"She was here for a long time? She left yesterday?"

She nodded, wiping away her tears with her arm.

"Do you know where she is?"

"Yes. She go far. Sand place."

"The desert?"

"Desert. I follow her yester day to desert. She not see. Not know I am there."

"Why did she leave?"

"I not know. Me, her, friends."

"You were friends?"

"Yes, I love her."

I sat there and watched as the little girl finally let her tears flow out. She put her hands to her face, as if she was embarrassed to be crying even though she was a child. I took my arms, tired as they were, and hugged her. In that moment, I felt an unmeasurable mountain of guilt and sadness pass over me again. Even now, Catra was still doing what she did best, disappointing people. First Adora left, then Catra turned on us. She turned on Scorpia, Entrapta, Hordak, and now Adora herself. Even this little girl, this poor, defenseless, immature little girl was a victim of hers. But still we all felt bad for her.

"Lonnie."

"Yes?"

"Promise. You not hurt her."

"I promise."

It was only our third day in Lagarto. I was somewhat enjoying our stay, the food was great and the people were friendly, but the looming sense of urgency hung over my head. We were on a mission. Each day, the group had split up to look for different clues. We had no idea what we were looking for, but we had to start somewhere. The four lower soldiers all took one part of the town to sweep through, north, south, east, and west, while I went to the law enforcement and tried to ask them about it. Our searches had been relatively barren, although we did find another cat woman. She wasn't Catra, but for a few minutes we all felt tense. Otherwise, the time was not the most productive.

On the third day, I went to a local bar and restaurant to eat. It looked inviting, although it was filled with the "bad type". Everyone had tattoos, wore dark clothing, and some of them were even repping the old Tung Lashor gang's insignia. I was too hungry to care, so I ordered some food and a drink and waited. No one really looked at me with the tough eyes or tried to steal my money, something I was not in the mood to deal with. Eventually, they served me my food and I got to eating. It was good food but not the most amazing thing ever; I could tell this was a newer restaurant made to serve semi-authentic food to outsiders. It was all decked out in tacky decorations and some odd music was playing. I finished up my plate and my drink, burped loudly, and got up to go use the bathroom. I was ready to start the rest of the day's worth of fruitless searching.

As I opened the door to the bathroom, I heard another person in a stall. I hated having to use the bathroom at the same time as somebody else, but it was urgent enough. I reluctantly got into a stall of my own. As I was washing my hands in the sink, the stall behind me opened. Out of it walked a woman with a covered face, arms, and legs. It was quite hot so I didn't know why she wanted so much of herself covered in black. That was until I noticed two ears perked up on the top of her head. Catra stopped in her tracks, as if she could see me.

"Lonnie?"

As I opened the black box, my heart slowly sank. In it was a small piece of paper attached to a small silver dagger. The note read: *Tell them she killed herself.* I wished the boat would start rocking again, the stillness was too much to handle.

The Pirate (interlude)

The pirate was not kind.

The pirate did not talk.

She did not free us because she liked us, she freed us because she had to.

We had been in different cells for weeks awaiting the day, but now we were finally together.

She stood there silently as the three of us hugged one another.

Our tears were wet, our feet were too.

The stone floors of the prison were lined with blood.

The guards lay dead on the ground.

The pirate had a dagger in her hand.

She had been taught how to fight by our friend.

She had been taught to kill by our friend.

We were going to get out of this alive.

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